The Core Business Assessment

Proof Your Business Model Carries Predictable Growth

For service businesses with $0–$500,000 in revenue.

SYNNOVATIA

Welcome!

My guess is, like many entrepreneurs, you feel stressed, overwhelmed, or like your business is running you instead of you running your business.

The good news is you're taking the first step towards a brighter future by evaluating your business with this assessment—something that's not easy when stress is your constant companion and the path forward is unclear.

I can assure you that this assessment is your ticket to gaining control of your business and creating predictable growth. I've seen countless entrepreneurs go through this process and come out the other side relieved, energized, and focused.

Whether you have more projects vying for your attention than time to give or simply aren't sure how to prioritize them, the Core Business Assessment helps sort it all out.

Once you complete the assessment, you'll have a clear picture of the current condition of your business, as well as the core area(s) to prioritize and strengthen. You'll also know exactly which areas you can safely set aside for later!

Caution: It's important to view this as a journey to your ultimate business destination. Don't be discouraged if your score isn't what you expect. Your score is neither good nor bad—it just is.

How to Use This Assessment

As an entrepreneur, predictable business growth is created through a regular practice of analyze → plan → execute → evaluate. To get the most from this assessment, think of it as a continual process rather than something you do once and dismiss.

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Instructions

1. Read each statement in each section.
Each of the 10 core business sections includes the statements most relevant to Stage I — 69 in total. Read each statement carefully and check the box if the statement is CONSISTENTLY TRUE for you. Leave the box blank until you have done what is necessary to make it consistently true.

2. Count the number of true statements in each section.
Compile the number of checked boxes of each of the 10 sections on the Progress Chart. Total your score (each statement is worth 1 point).

3. Review your results.
Which areas are strongest? Which ones need attention? Did anything surprise you? We'll get into this at the end of this assessment, including how to evaluate your results and prioritize the area(s) of focus.

One more thing . . .

Like most things in business and life, you get out of this what you put into it. To ensure you get the most from this assessment, I have two recommendations:

1. Go deep.
Get into the data of your business. For the consistently true statements, do you have proof to back up your answer? Are there testimonials that show you're doing it right? Take the time to dig in and get the real picture. The deeper you go, the more this assessment helps you make strategic choices to move your business forward.

2. Review this assessment with a trusted business coach or advisor.
It's hard to be objective about your own business when you're this close to it. An outside, unbiased perspective keeps you honest about what you see. If you'd like to walk through your results together, book time directly on my calendar. (Your first conversation is on me.)

Find a Time That Works

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The Core Business Assessment

Business Foundation Development

Fundamental to the success of any business is having a strong foundation from which to grow. It's important to take the time to determine your plans, goals, and strategies to understand where you are now and where you want to be in the future. A wise man said, "If you don't have time to do it right the first time, how much time do you have to do it over?"

- ☐ I know exactly what business I'm in.
- ☐ I have a clear understanding of my present and future clients, their needs, and how they acquire their products and services.
- ☐ My mission statement fully reflects my values.
- ☐ My vision is clear, concise, and a daily source of inspiration.
- ☐ I know the strengths and limitations of my competitors and have properly positioned my company.
- ☐ I have identified my company's strengths, limitations, and competitive advantage.
- ☐ My company's primary aim provides direction and focus that is used as a standard for measuring my progress.
- ☐ My business goals and objectives are in alignment with my personal goals and objectives.
- ☐ I assess and upgrade my business plan every 90 days.

TOTAL (out of 9): 0

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Product and Service Development

Products and services are the lifeblood of an organization. Your business must be good at finding and growing successful products and services to obtain sustainable growth.

- [ ] My product and service are in the right market, designed well, positioned correctly, and priced appropriately.
- [ ] Open market segments in which I can profitably compete are known.
- [ ] Pricing of products and services is based on an effective pricing model rather than ad hoc.
- [ ] My product and service design meet the needs of our target audience rather than my personal needs.
- [ ] I clearly recognize which market tier for which my product and service is best suited.
- [ ] I have the plan, the patience, and the persistence to ensure a thriving product and service launch.
- [ ] I am acquainted with the characteristics, objectives, and strategies of product and service lifecycles.
- [ ] I know the current lifecycle my product and service are experiencing.

TOTAL (out of 8): 0

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Marketing and Branding Strategies

Regular evaluation and rejuvenation of your marketing tactics ensures brand strength and relevance. Building brand equity while delivering superior satisfaction creates beneficial relationships in the marketplace.

- ☐ I know, understand, and have a plan for building customer relationships through the nine stages of trust.
- ☐ I am able to clearly articulate my company's brand position.
- ☐ I have a well-designed value proposition that sets my business apart from my competition and compels my target audience to act.
- ☐ I know the most critical features and benefits that create an advantage.
- ☐ I implement marketing tactics that produce results and support my product and service.
- ☐ I have a system for continuous communication with my target audience.
- ☐ My collateral material consistently reflects the quality of my brand.
- ☐ I employ a budget to guide my marketing decisions.

TOTAL (out of 8): 0

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Accounting and Financial Growth

Following sound accounting procedures and a precise budget are critical to ensuring funds are accurately flowing in and out of your business to meet financial expectations and sustain profitability.

- ☐ I use a detailed budget that guides my decisions.
- ☐ I consistently use the three principal financial statements to measure and report the results of my business activity.
- ☐ I know the two primary ways to increase the bottom-line and have a plan for each.
- ☐ I have identified the company's intangible and tangible assets.
- ☐ My revenue is growing in sales and profits.
- ☐ Necessary local, state, and federal documents and taxes are filed and paid on time.

TOTAL (out of 6): 0

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Sales Tools and Growth

Selling is the arm of marketing that builds long-lasting relationships. Understanding your customers, their needs, and developing appropriate selling techniques for your products and services is essential to your success as an entrepreneur.

- ☐ I have a procedure that produces a consistent experience during each and every encounter for my customers.
- ☐ Sales goals inspire performance and are met or exceeded daily.
- ☐ A system for measuring the effectiveness of my sales efforts is in place.
- ☐ I know the buying decision process.
- ☐ I understand the buying behaviors of my target audience and am able to speak my customer's language.
- ☐ I have suitable technology that allows me to sell effectively.
- ☐ I use selling techniques that pull (attract) customers rather than push (seduce) customers.
- ☐ Sales are increasing.

TOTAL (out of 8): 0

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Serving Clients and Generating Referrals

Regular engagement allows you to better serve your clients by anticipating their needs. Serving your clients and assisting in their success leads to customer retention and the opportunity for referrals.

- ☐ The theory of 250 influences my interactions with every client.
- ☐ I make two service upgrades when each client leaves my business.
- ☐ I have relationships with “centers of influence” who provide quality referrals.
- ☐ My customers know I am looking for more business and the type of clients I best serve.
- ☐ I fully understand what my clients value by recognizing my client’s “vision”.
- ☐ I know the “moments of truth”—those times that can sell or sour a client instantaneously regardless of the length of time the client has been associated with my business.

TOTAL (out of 6): 0

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Operational System Development

Operational systems are the glue that holds your business together. Smooth operating systems keep your business performing—even when you, the owner, are absent.

- ☐ My business operations are capable of functioning day-to-day, effectively and efficiently delivering products and services.
- ☐ My business has the necessary protection it needs, such as legal agreements, insurance, business licenses and permits, software backup systems, etc.
- ☐ I have the proper equipment, software, and supplies that permit me to function as a first-class operation.
- ☐ Excellence is my operating standard; nothing is thrown together, substandard, or ridden with inaccuracies.

TOTAL (out of 4): 0

Personnel and Vendor Development

An investment in the skills, knowledge, and experience of your staff is as important as your infrastructure investment. Select your vendors carefully to ensure they are equally committed to the high standards you place upon yourself and your business.

- ☐ My vendors (i.e., CPA, attorney, business strategist, graphic/web designer, marketing consultant, etc.) are dependable, governed by standards of excellence, and committed to ongoing learning.
- ☐ I know which roles are best filled by an employee versus a contractor at this stage of my business.
- ☐ Anyone I bring on, whether an employee or a contractor, has a clear picture of what success in their role looks like.
- ☐ I have a backup plan if a key vendor or contractor becomes unavailable.
- ☐ I know which tasks I should hand off first as I bring on help.

TOTAL (out of 5): 0

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Business Skill Growth

Mastering your craft is simply the first step for sustainable business growth. Developing your business skills strengthens your chance for success.

- ☐ I know the three most critical issues facing my business and have a plan in place to address them.
- ☐ I base my decisions on values, mission, vision and principles rather than fear and needs.
- ☐ I know and understand the importance of various business functions such as market research, strategic planning, profit orientation, sales pro forma, brand positioning, value proposition, projections, etc.
- ☐ I am committed to personal and professional life-long learning.
- ☐ Key decision-making points are based on research and careful consideration rather than on a “hunch” or “whim”.
- ☐ I have what it takes to be successful (i.e., ambition, dedication, courage, initiative, and willingness to risk).

TOTAL (out of 6): 0

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Entrepreneur Performance and Foundation

The quality of your performance as an entrepreneur and the success of your business are dependent upon your physical and mental wellness.

- ☐ I am guided daily by goal management rather than time management. In so doing, I make the most of my time.
- ☐ There is nothing that I tolerate at work.
- ☐ I have an intriguing and satisfying life away from the office.
- ☐ I move (walk/run/jog/bike/hike) a minimum of three days each week.
- ☐ Effectiveness takes a priority over efficiency.
- ☐ I continually under promise and over deliver.
- ☐ I am committed to providing BIG results for myself and others.
- ☐ I am aware of my primary personal needs and have a plan outside of the business to get my needs met.
- ☐ I have confidence in my strengths, my abilities, and myself. I am guided by a healthy dose of optimism.

TOTAL (out of 9): 0

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Progress Chart

	Business Foundation (of 9)	Product and Service (of 8)	Marketing and Branding (of 8)	Accounting and Financial (of 6)	Sales Tools and Growth (of 8)	Serve Client and Referrals (of 6)	Operational System (of 4)	Personnel and Vendor (of 5)	Business Skill (of 6)	Entrepreneur Performance (of 9)
Totals	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0

TOTAL SCORE (out of 69) 0

Date	Score	+/- Points

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Turn Your Score into Action

How did you do? Was there anything that surprised you? Again, don't worry if you didn't get the score you were hoping for—this is your roadmap. It's an opportunity to take a step in the right direction!

That said, while knowledge is half of the battle, action is the other half. Here are easy and tangible ways to turn your score into an action plan.

1. Evaluate your results.
Summarize each section. Compile the number of checked boxes of each of the 10 sections on the progress chart.

2. Select one core area to strengthen first. Just one!
As author Gary Keller is fond of saying "What's the ONE Thing you can do such that by doing it everything else will be easier or unnecessary?" That's the thing you want to select. While this may be difficult, focusing your efforts on improving a single area with maximum impact strengthens your business more quickly than working on multiple areas simultaneously.

3. Create a SMART goal.
Make sure it is specific, measurable, attainable (within your 90-day window!), realistic, and tightly focused (SMART). Set your goal and work backwards . . . what actions do you need to take and in what order to achieve your goal? Build a series of action steps or tactics to move your business forward.

4. Reassess every 90 days.
As with any map, check it repeatedly to navigate your business to success. Make sure to reevaluate and rescore yourself regularly to track your progress and keep yourself moving forward!

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